

The Exorcism of Emily Rose

Extreme Ultra-Density Draft: Chapters 1 & 2

THE EXORCISM OF EMILY ROSE

PART I: THE BODY / THE CASE OPENS

CHAPTER 1: 3:00

The digital clock on the nightstand did not tick. It burned.

Red numbers floating in the dark, composed of segmented LEDs that buzzed with a frequency just on the edge of human hearing.

2:59.

Erin Bruner lay on her back, her arms at her sides, mimicking the posture of a corpse or a saint. She wasn't sure which.

She was awake. She had been awake since she got into bed at 11:30, after two glasses of Chardonnay that had tasted like oak and regret. The wine was supposed to be a sedative. Instead, it had turned into acid in her stomach, a slow, burning reminder that her body was not a machine, no matter how much she treated it like one.

The condo was silent. It was a silence she had paid a premium for. The building was called *The Spire*, a shard of glass and steel thrusting forty stories into the Chicago sky. Her unit was on the thirty-fourth floor. Up here, the city noise—the sirens, the honking, the desperate shouting of the Loop—was filtered out by triple-paned, argon-filled glass. The only sound was the low, rhythmic thrum of the HVAC system, breathing processed air into the room.

Hhhhuuuuh. Hhhhuuuuh.

It sounded like an iron lung.

Erin stared at the ceiling. It was painted "Gallery White," a color her interior designer had promised would "open up the space." In the dark, it looked like grey slate.

She closed her eyes, trying to summon the sleep that hovered just out of reach.

Focus on the breath, Dr. Evans had said. *In for four. Hold for four. Out for four.*

Erin tried.

In... two... three... four.

Hold... two... three... four.

But the silence wasn't empty. It was crowded.

Thoughts swarmed in the dark like gnats.

Did I file the motion to suppress for the Henderson case? Yes.

Did I pick up my dry cleaning? No. Damn it.

James Van Hopper.

The name hit her like a physical blow. A heavy stone dropped into the well of her mind.

Tomorrow was the verdict.

She saw Van Hopper's face. The way his left eye twitched when he lied. The way his hands, small and pale, looked like spiders resting on the defense table.

She knew he did it.

She knew he had wrapped that telephone cord—a vintage, beige coil, the kind that stretches—around his wife's neck. She knew he had pulled until her hyoid bone snapped.

She knew it because he had told her, in the privileged silence of the attorney-client room.

"She wouldn't stop screaming, Erin. I just wanted quiet."

And Erin had given him quiet. She had given him "Reasonable Doubt." She had taken the neighbor's testimony—an old woman with cataracts—and shredded it until it looked like confetti.

I am a good lawyer, she told herself. *Everyone deserves a defense. It is the system. It is the Constitution.*

But in the dark, the Constitution felt very thin.

She opened her eyes.

The clock still read *2:59.*

Had it been a minute? Or an hour?

She rolled over, the 800-thread-count Egyptian cotton sheets feeling cool and slick against her skin. Too slick. Like sleeping on ice.

She looked at the window.

The city was a grid of amber and neon blue, blurred by the rain that was streaking the glass. Chicago. The City of Broad Shoulders. Tonight, it looked like a circuit board shorting out.

Then, it happened.

The change.

It wasn't a sound. It was a shift in pressure.

Erin's ears popped. *Click.*

The hum of the HVAC system stopped. Abruptly. Like someone had cut the power line.

The silence that followed was absolute. It was heavy. Viscous. It pressed against her eardrums.

Erin held her breath.

Power outage?

She looked at the clock.

The red numbers flickered once.

Then they changed.

3:00.

The colon between the numbers—the two little red dots—stopped blinking.

Usually, it pulsed. *On. Off. On. Off.* One second.

Now, it was just... On.

Static.

Frozen.

Erin stared at it.

Come on, she thought. *Blink.*

It didn't blink.

A chill walked up her legs. Not the cool of the AC. This was a deep, bone-aching cold. It felt like the temperature in the room had dropped twenty degrees in a second.

She pulled the duvet up to her chin.

It's just the thermostat. It's just a glitch.

But her heart didn't believe her. Her heart was hammering against her ribs, a frantic, trapped bird.
Thump-thump-thump-thump.

Then came the smell.

It started faint, a tickle in the back of her nose.

Erin sniffed.

Sniff.

Burning?

She sat up, panic flaring. *Did I leave the stove on? The curling iron?*

But it wasn't smoke. Not wood smoke. Not food.

It was sharp. Acrid.

Sulfur.

Like a match that had been struck and blown out, multiplied by a thousand.

And underneath the sulfur... something else. Something wet and metallic.

Copper.

It tasted like she was chewing on a penny. The back of her tongue coated in a slick, oily film.

Old blood.

And rotting flowers. That distinct, cloying sweetness of lilies that have been left in a vase too long, the water turning grey and slimy. The smell of a funeral home after the guests have left.

"Jasper?" she whispered.

Her voice sounded wrong. Thin. Flat. As if the air in the room was too thin to carry the sound waves.

Jasper, her Persian cat, usually slept at the foot of the bed. He was a heavy, lazy animal, a comforting anchor of warmth.

The bed was light.

Erin scanned the room.

The door to the bedroom was ajar. Just an inch.

Through the crack, she could see into the hallway.

It was dark.

But not empty.

There was a shadow in the hall.

Erin blinked.

It's just the coat rack. It's just the angle of the streetlights.

But the shadow moved.

It didn't walk. It didn't slide. It *poured*. Like liquid ink, it seemed to seep from the ceiling down the wall, pooling on the floor.

Erin slid her legs out of bed. Her feet touched the carpet.

It was wet.

She gasped, pulling her feet back.

She reached down and touched the rug.

Dry.

Bone dry.

She frowned. *I felt it. It was cold and wet.*

She tried again.

Dry.

You're losing it, Bruner. You're cracking up.

She grabbed the lamp from the nightstand. It was a brass sculpture, heavy and jagged. A weapon.

She stood up. Her silk nightgown whispered against her legs.

She walked to the door.

"Jasper?"

She pushed the door open.

The hallway was empty. The shadow was gone.

But the smell was stronger here. It was choking.

Erin coughed, covering her mouth with her hand. The taste of copper was overwhelming.

She walked into the living room.

The room was bathed in the orange glow of the city. The furniture cast long, distorted shadows.

Jasper was there.

He was standing on the back of the white leather sofa.

He wasn't sleeping. He wasn't grooming.

He was hunting.

His back was arched so high his spine looked like a saw blade. His fur was standing straight up, making him look twice his size. His tail was a bottle brush of terror.

He was hissing.

Hsssssss.

A low, continuous sound, like gas escaping a valve.

He wasn't looking at Erin.

He was looking at the corner of the room.

At the Eames lounge chair.

The chair Erin's father had given her when she made Partner. "A chair for a shark," he had said.

Erin looked at the chair.

It was empty.

The black leather gleamed in the half-light.

But as she watched... the leather moved.

Creak.

It was the sound of weight settling. The sound of foam compressing.

The seat cushion depressed.

A perfect, circular depression appeared in the center of the seat.

Then the backrest groaned. Two indentations appeared, as if shoulders were pressing back.

Someone was sitting in her chair.

Someone invisible.

Erin froze. Every instinct in her body screamed *RUN*.

But she couldn't move. She was rooted to the floor, witnessing the impossible.

"Who's there?" she whispered.

Silence.

Then, a sound.

Tap. Tap. Tap.

Fingernails on leather.

Rhythmic. Impatient.

The depression in the seat shifted.

The leather groaned again. *Eeeeeeeee.*

The invisible figure was leaning forward.

Towards her.

Erin saw the air in front of the chair shimmer. Like heat haze on asphalt.

But it wasn't heat. It was cold.

Frost began to bloom on the leather. White, crystalline patterns spreading across the black surface like a disease.

The smell of sulfur spiked, so strong Erin gagged.

And then she heard it.

Not with her ears.

Inside her head.

A voice.

It sounded like radio static tuning into a frequency.

"...Erin..."

It wasn't a human voice. It was a collage of sounds. The screech of metal, the drone of insects, the wet slap of meat.

"...we know..."

The lamp slipped from Erin's sweaty palm.

She caught it, fumbling, the brass clinking against her ring.

The sound broke the spell.

Erin turned and ran.

She sprinted back to the bedroom, her bare feet slapping against the hardwood floor. She slammed the door and locked it. She threw the deadbolt.

She grabbed the heavy oak dresser and dragged it across the floor. *SCREEEEEECH.*

She shoved it against the door.

She backed away, scrambling onto the bed, pulling her knees to her chest.

She clutched the lamp like a holy relic.

"Go away," she whispered. "Go away."

She stared at the door handle.

It didn't turn.

Nothing pounded on the wood.

The condo was silent again.

But it was a different kind of silence. It was the silence of a held breath.

Erin looked at the clock.

3:00.

Still.

It had been minutes. Five minutes? Ten?

The numbers burned.

The colon was solid.

Time had stopped.

Erin looked at her wristwatch on the dresser.

The second hand was twitching.

Tick-tick. Tick-tick. Tick-tick.

Stuck on the 12.

Fighting to move, but held back by an invisible finger.

Erin squeezed her eyes shut.

"It's a dream," she said aloud. "It's a lucid dream. Wake up. Wake up."

She pinched her arm. Hard.

Pain. Sharp and real.

She opened her eyes.

3:00.

She looked at the window.

The rain had stopped. The drops on the glass were frozen. Suspended in defiance of gravity.

"Oh god," Erin whispered.

She wasn't religious. She hadn't been to Mass in twenty years.

But in that moment, in the freezing cold of her bedroom, with the smell of hell in her nose, the words came back.

Hail Mary, full of grace...

She whispered them.

...the Lord is with thee...

The door handle jiggled.

Just once.

Clack.

Erin screamed. A short, sharp sound that tore her throat.

...pray for us sinners...

...now and at the hour of our death...

Blink.

The clock changed.

3:01.

The colon pulsed. *On. Off. On. Off.*

The HVAC system roared back to life. *Whirrrrr.*

The rain on the window slid down the glass.

Time started.

Erin sat there, gasping for air, her chest heaving.

The smell was gone. Instantly. Replaced by the scent of lavender detergent and her own sweat.

She lowered the lamp.

Her hands were shaking so hard the brass rattled.

She sat there for a long time. Ten minutes. Twenty.

Waiting.

Nothing happened.

Just the city. Just the night.

Finally, she stood up. Her legs felt like jelly.

She moved the dresser.

She unlocked the door.

She opened it slowly.

"Jasper?"

The cat trotted in from the living room. He meowed, rubbing against her leg, purring.

He looked fine. His fur was flat. His tail was up.

Erin picked him up, burying her face in his fur. He smelled like cat food and dust.

Normal smells.

"You saw it," she whispered into his fur. "I know you saw it."

Jasper just purred.

Erin walked into the living room.

She turned on every light. The overheads. The lamps. The kitchen track lighting.

She flooded the condo with artificial brilliance.

She looked at the Eames chair.

It was empty. The leather was smooth. No depression. No frost.

She walked over to it. She touched the leather.

It was warm.

Room temperature.

"I'm losing my mind," she said. "Van Hopper. It's the stress."

She walked to the kitchen island to pour herself a glass of water. Her throat was parched.

She took a sip.

It tasted fine. Clean. Filtered.

She leaned against the counter, closing her eyes.

Get a grip, Bruner. You have court in six hours.

She opened her eyes.

She looked at the granite countertop.

Her notepad was there. The legal pad she used for midnight ideas.

She had left it closed. She always closed it. Confidentiality habit.

It was open.

Erin frowned.

She walked over to it.

On the yellow page, there was a drawing.

It was crude. Done in charcoal? No. She didn't own charcoal.

It was done in soot.

Black, oily soot.

It was a drawing of a face.

A screaming face.

The mouth was unhinged, too wide, a black pit of despair. The eyes were scratched out.

And underneath the face, three words were written in jagged, violent strokes.

WE ARE HERE.

Erin stared at the words.

She reached out a trembling finger.

She touched the black line.

It came away on her skin. Greasy. Cold.

She smelled her finger.

Sulfur.

She hadn't drawn it.

She lived alone.

She looked back at the empty chair in the living room.

And for the first time in her life, Erin Bruner knew that "Reasonable Doubt" was a lie.

There was no doubt.

She was not alone.

CHAPTER 2: ARRAIGNMENT

The morning after the Van Hopper verdict, the sun didn't rise so much as the grey sky just got slightly brighter. It was a Chicago morning—relentless, industrial, and cold. The kind of morning that felt like a hangover even if you hadn't been drinking.

Erin Bruner stood in front of her bathroom mirror. The glass was fogged with steam, turning her reflection into a ghost.

She wiped a circle clear with her palm.

Her eyes looked back at her. Blue. Sharp. But underneath, there was a web of red capillaries.

Sleep deprivation, she told herself. *Just stress.*

She looked at her finger. The index finger of her right hand.

She had scrubbed it with a pumice stone for ten minutes. The skin was pink and raw. But she could still feel the soot. A phantom stain. A greasy, cold sensation that seemed to have seeped into her pores.

She turned on the tap. Scalding hot water. She held her finger under the stream until the pain was a sharp, clarifying focus.

Pain is real, she thought. *Soot drawings that appear out of nowhere are not.*

She dressed in her armor.

A charcoal grey suit, tailored to within a millimeter of perfection. A silk blouse, cream-colored, that cost more than her first car. Stiletto heels that were weapons of psychological warfare.

She was Erin Bruner. She was a Senior Partner in waiting. She was the woman who let James Van Hopper walk.

She wasn't afraid of the dark.

She drove to the office on autopilot. Her Mercedes SL cut through the morning traffic like a shark through a school of minnows. The leather steering wheel was cool under her palms. The radio was playing NPR, a drone of bad news about the economy and the Middle East.

She turned it off.

She preferred the silence.

Or she thought she did.

But in the silence of the car, she heard it again.

Scritch.

From the back seat.

She jerked her head up, staring into the rearview mirror.

Empty leather seats.

Just a receipt from the dry cleaners fluttering in the vent air.

"Get a grip, Bruner," she said aloud. Her voice sounded too loud in the confined space. "You're cracking up. You need a vacation. Tahiti. Somewhere without extradition treaties."

The firm was buzzing. The "Victory Lap" had turned into a "Victory March."

Paralegals smiled at her with that mix of fear and adoration she had cultivated for a decade. Junior associates got out of her way, pressing themselves against the corridor walls as if her ambition was contagious.

Ray, her second chair on the Van Hopper case, was waiting by her office door. He looked fresh, rested. He probably slept like a baby. He probably didn't have soot on his fingers.

"Boss," he said, grinning. "The press is calling. CNN wants a statement. The Times wants an interview. *Dateline* is asking for exclusivity. They want the 'Inside Story' of how you broke the witness."

"Tell them no comment," Erin said, unlocking her door.

Ray blinked. "No comment? Erin, you're the 'Giant Killer.' You should be taking a lap. This is free publicity. This is the cover of *American Lawyer*."

"I'm taking a coffee, Ray. And aspirin. And silence. Hold my calls."

She went into her office and shut the door.

She leaned against the heavy wood, closing her eyes.

The silence of the office was usually a comfort. Today, it felt oppressive. The air was too filtered. The light was too artificial. It felt like being inside a very expensive coffin.

She walked to her desk.

There was a file on it.

A red folder. *Urgent.*

A sticky note from Karl: *See me. Now.*

Erin dropped her bag and walked to the corner office.

Karl Gunderson was on the phone, looking out at the city. He waved her in.

"I know," he was saying into the receiver. "I know it's a disaster. We'll contain it. We always contain it."

He hung up.

He turned to Erin. He looked serious. Not the shark-smile serious. Real serious. The kind of serious that meant money was bleeding.

"Sit down."

Erin sat in one of the leather guest chairs. It was low, forcing her to look up at him. A classic power move. She hated it.

"Who's the disaster?" she asked.

"The Archdiocese."

"The priest case?"

"Father Richard Moore. He was arraigned this morning. The judge denied bail."

"Denied bail? On a negligent homicide? That's aggressive. Usually, they bond out on ROR. Unless he has a record?"

"No record. He's a parish priest. But the judge is Brewster."

"Brewster?" Erin scoffed. "He's up for re-election. He wants to look tough on... what? Religion?"

"Weirdness," Karl said. "The DA... Ethan Thomas... he made a show of it. Called Moore a 'flight risk to the spiritual plane' or some nonsense. He played up the 'cult leader' angle. It worked. Moore is in County. Solitary."

Karl slid the file across the desk.

"I need you to go down there. Now."

"To the jail?"

"To take the case."

Erin hesitated. She looked at the file. *The People vs. Richard Moore.*

"Karl, I just finished a six-month murder trial. I need a break. I need... sleep."

"You need the Senior Partnership," Karl said softly.

He leaned forward.

"And this is the price of admission."

He tapped the file.

"If you win this... if you save the Church from a hundred-million-dollar liability suit... you can write your own ticket. You can have my job when I retire. You can have the world."

"And if I lose?"

"Don't lose."

The drive to the County Jail was a descent into the underworld.

Erin turned off the highway, leaving the gleaming glass canyons of the Loop behind. The scenery changed instantly. The architecture of wealth—glass, steel, light—gave way to the architecture of poverty. Brick. Concrete. Iron.

Broken sidewalks. Boarded-up storefronts. Liquor stores with bars on the windows.

It was Dante's circles, manifest in urban planning.

The rain picked up, smearing the windshield with grey sludge. The wipers fought a losing battle.

Thwump-hiss. Thwump-hiss.

The jail itself was a fortress. A brutalist block of concrete surrounded by razor wire that glistened in the rain. It looked like a tomb for the living.

Erin parked in the visitor's lot. She checked her reflection in the mirror.

Perfect. Impenetrable.

But her hands were shaking.

Just a little.

It's the coffee, she told herself. *Too much caffeine.*

But she knew it wasn't the coffee.

It was the lingering smell of copper in her nose.

She walked into the intake center.

The smell hit her first.

It wasn't just a smell; it was a physical presence. A wall of odor.

Industrial pine cleaner trying to mask the scent of unwashed bodies. Stale cigarette smoke. Urine. And underneath it all, the metallic tang of fear. It was the smell of caged animals.

Erin breathed through her mouth.

She checked her bag with the guard, a woman named Officer Higgins. Higgins had tired eyes and a belt weighed down by keys, a radio, and pepper spray. She was chewing gum with a slow, bovine rhythm.

"Attorney visit for Moore," Erin said, sliding her bar card across the scratched plexiglass.

Higgins looked at the card, then at Erin.

"The Exorcist guy?"

"Father Moore."

"Yeah. He's in D Block. Watch yourself, honey. He's spooky."

"Spooky how?" Erin asked, clipping the visitor badge to her lapel.

"Just... stares. And the other inmates? They don't like him. They scream when he walks by. Like dogs barking at a storm."

Erin walked through the metal detector. *Beep.*

"Underwire," she muttered.

Higgins waved the wand. "Go ahead."

The corridors were long, echoey tunnels of concrete painted a color that could only be described as "institutional despair green."

Clack. Clack. Clack.

Erin's heels sounded like gunshots in the silence.

She passed the communal cells in B Block. Usually, the inmates catcalled her. *Hey baby. Nice legs. Come here.*

Today, they were silent.

They watched her pass with dark, hooded eyes. Hands gripping the bars.

Some of them made signs. Hand gestures. Warding off evil? Or inviting it?

One man, his face covered in tattoos, hissed as she passed.

"We see you," he whispered.

Erin didn't flinch. She stared straight ahead.

But the back of her neck prickled.

She reached the interview room at the end of D Block.

The guard unlocked the heavy steel door. *Clang.*

"He's in there. Good luck."

Erin stepped inside.

The room was small, windowless. A metal table bolted to the floor. Two chairs. A two-way mirror that everyone pretended wasn't there.

Father Richard Moore sat in the far chair.

He was wearing his clerical collar, but his shirt was wrinkled, stained with sweat. He looked thin. Gaunt. Like he hadn't eaten in weeks.

But it was his stillness that struck her.

He wasn't fidgeting. He wasn't pacing. He sat with his hands folded on the table, perfectly motionless. Like a statue carved from grey stone.

He didn't look up when she entered.

"Father Moore?"

He slowly raised his head.

His eyes.

Erin had seen a lot of eyes. Killers, liars, victims. Dead eyes. Crazy eyes.

Moore's eyes were different.

They were deep. Infinite. And terrified.

Not terrified of her. Terrified of what he had seen. Terrified of what he knew.

"I'm Erin Bruner," she said, setting her briefcase down. *Click.* "I'm your attorney."

Moore looked at the briefcase. Then at her.

"You're the one," he said. His voice was rough, unused. Gravel tumbling down a chute.

"The one?"

"The one they sent."

"The Archdiocese sent me. Yes."

"Not the Archdiocese," Moore whispered.

He leaned forward. The chains on his wrists rattled. *Chink-chink.*

"Do you believe in the Devil, Ms. Bruner?"

Erin paused. It was the standard question. Every religious nut she defended asked it. It was a test. A way to see if she was "one of them."

"I believe in the Constitution, Father. And I believe in the Rules of Evidence."

Moore smiled. It was a sad, broken smile.

"That's a pity," he said. "Because the Devil believes in you."

Erin felt a chill run down her spine. The same copper taste filled her mouth. The taste from 3:00 AM.

"Let's focus on the case," she said, opening her notebook. She clicked her pen. "Ethan Thomas is charging you with negligent homicide. He says you told Emily Rose to stop her medication."

"I told her to trust God."

"In the eyes of the law, that's the same thing as negligence."

"Then the law is blind."

"The law is a tool, Father. And right now, it's a tool being used to crush you. I can stop that. But you have to work with me. You have to tell me exactly what happened in that barn."

Moore looked away. He looked at the two-way mirror. He seemed to be looking through it, seeing something on the other side.

"The barn," he whispered.

"Yes. The night she died."

"She didn't die," Moore said. "She was released."

"Father..."

"You want to know what happened?" Moore looked back at her. His intensity was physically palpable, like heat radiating from a furnace. "We opened a door. And something came through. Something that had been waiting a long time."

"Something?"

"We are Legion," Moore quoted. "For we are many."

Erin wrote it down. *Client delusional? Religious fixation.*

But her hand shook. The pen wavered on the page.

"We'll enter a plea of Not Guilty," she said. "We'll argue... alternative causality. Psychosis induced by stress."

"You can argue whatever you want," Moore said. "But be warned, Erin Bruner."

"Warned of what?"

Moore reached out. He touched her hand.

His skin was ice cold.

"Once you look at the darkness," he whispered. "The darkness looks back. It knows your name now."

Erin pulled her hand away.

"I'm a lawyer, Father. I deal in facts."

"Then here is a fact," Moore said. "It's 3:00 AM. Do you know why you wake up at 3:00 AM?"

Erin froze.

How did he know?

"It's the mocking of the Trinity," Moore said softly. "The inverse of 3:00 PM. The miracle hour. The hour of death. The hour when the veil is thinnest."

Erin stood up. She packed her bag. She needed to get out of there. The air in the room was suffocating. It smelled of sulfur and fear.

"I'll... I'll see you at the bail hearing."

She knocked on the door. "Guard!"

As the door opened, she looked back.

Moore was back in his statue pose. Staring at his hands.

"Pray," he whispered. "Pray for protection."

Erin walked out into the corridor.

She walked fast.

She didn't look at the inmates.

She got to the lobby and burst out into the rain.

She took a deep breath of the wet, smoggy air. It tasted like freedom.

He's crazy, she told herself. *He's just a crazy priest.*

But she looked at her watch.

The second hand was moving.

Tick-tick.

She got in her car.

She looked in the rearview mirror.

Her eyes looked tired. Scared.

"Get a grip," she said aloud.

But she knew.

The game had changed.

This wasn't Van Hopper. This wasn't a murder trial.

This was something else.

And she was already in deep water.